Today's goal • 0/3 items
Complete 3 items today to stay at a good pace!

Module 1
Introduction to What Is Contemporary Art?

Module 2
Media from Television to the Internet

Module 3
Territories & Transit

Module 4
Materials & Making

Module 5
Agency

Visibility
- ✓ Introduction to Module 5
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Pope.L's New York crawls
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ In New York City with Pope.L | Direct action
  Video • 4 min
- ✓ Two artists consider Catherine Opie, Dyke, 1993
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Tania Bruguera on Untitled (Havana, 2000), 2000
  Video • 4 min
- ✓ Luis Camnitzer on Memorial, 2009
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Yara Said on the Refugee Flag, 2016
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Firelei Báez on For Améthyste and Athénaire (Exiled Muses Beyond Jean Luc Nancy's Canon), Anacaonas, 2018
  Reading • 10 min

Voice
- ✓ Who speaks?
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Nick Cave on Soundsuit, 2011
  Video • 2 min
- ✓ Lawrence Abu Hamdan, Conflicted Phonemes, 2012
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ **P Staff on Weed Killer, 2017**
  Reading • 10 min

Action
- ○ Taking action
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Lorraine O'Grady on Mlle Bourgeoise Noire, 1980–83/2009
  Video • 2 min
- ○ Xiao Lu on Dialogue, 1989
  Video • 2 min
- ○ Ralph Borland, Suited for Subversion (Prototype), 2002
  Video • 1 min
- ○ Defining and blurring identities through performance
  Reading • 10 min

Review & Respond
- ○ Memory Check
  Practice Assignment
- ○ Reflect on Agency in Module 5
  Dialogue • 15 min
- ○ Optional Readings & Resources
  Reading • 10 min

Module 6
Power

Exposing Power
- ○ Introduction to Module 6
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Instructor Christian Rattemeyer on Mark Lombardi's diagrams of power
  Video • 6 min
- ○ What do war and peace have to do with chandeliers and portraits?
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Deana Lawson on Nation, 2017
  Video • 2 min

Abuse of Power
- ○ How do artists critique power?
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Two responses to abuse of power
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Wolfgang Tillmans on Sendeschluss / End of Broadcast I, 2014
  Video • 2 min

Sources of Power
- ○ Power: sources and resources
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Outer space to inner earth
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Curator Paola Antonelli on Massoud Hassani's Mine Kafon wind-powered deminer, 2011
  Video • 1 min
- ○ Rania Ghosn on After Oil, 2016
  Video • 4 min

Review & Respond
- ○ Memory Check
  Practice Assignment
- ○ Reflecting on Power in Art
  Dialogue • 15 min
- ○ Final course reflection
  Graded Assignment • 30 min
- ○ Optional Readings & Resources
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ End-of-course survey
  Reading • 5 min
- ○ Recordings of live virtual sessions (optional)
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ MoMA Resources
  Reading • 10 min

P Staff on Weed Killer, 2017

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P Staff's video installation *Weed Killer* is an adaptation of writer, artist, and curator Catherine Lord's book, *The Summer of Her Baldness: A Cancer Improvisation*. Staff cast an actor to relate Lord's story of her experience of illness and treatment, while surreal visuals throughout show the body in ways that can't be seen with the naked eye. Instructor Erica Papernik corresponded with P Staff about their work.

Erica Papernik, MoMA: Who is Catherine Lord and what drew you to her memoir?

P Staff: Catherine Lord is a writer, artist, and curator. We became friends when I asked her to write about a previous work of mine. I had admired her work for a long time. I read her memoir shortly after a close friend and mentor died of cancer, which was deeply affecting, but I was also struck by the way her analysis of the semiotics of illness and the rippling effects within a community closely paralleled my own experiences of being transgender.

P Staff. Still from *Weed Killer*. 2017. Video (color, sound) 16:49 min. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Fund for the Twenty-First Century. © 2019 Patrick Staff. Courtesy the artist

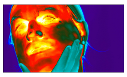
Why did you decide to use an actor to narrate Catherine Lord's memoir, as opposed to creating a documentary film with Lord?

Someone should make a documentary about Catherine. However, I am an artist, that's not what I do. In a way, I couldn't help but make something more complicated. The book is an account of Catherine's experience of breast cancer, radiation, and chemotherapy, and the effects on her body and relationships. In the video, I use a section of the book that reflects upon this chemically induced devastation of the body. The work explores the intersection of gender, illness, and contamination, as well as the meeting of my own biography with another person's. It ultimately becomes a reflection on what it means to survive on one's own terms. It becomes something new.

***Weed Killer* is rooted in a cross-generational exchange with Lord. What discoveries did you make through exploring the potential for and importance of dialogues that transcend space, time, and subject? How do Lord's writings and your own perspective overlap?**

While it is a cross-generational exchange, I sometimes think that that description is a little misleading, too simple maybe. Catherine and I share intellectual, artistic interests. We also gossip. I am also compelled to try to impress her, maybe I have an unexpected crush on her. These things could be said to typify a certain type of cross-generational exchange, but that feels too clinical a description for what is really going on, which is affection, attraction, admiration—all a little bit messy.

There is something unusual, or difficult, about transposing Catherine's experience of chemotherapy and radiation into mine of being transgender. In some ways these are tenuous connections, but my hope is that our subjectivities begin to unravel, and I can dig deeper into both.



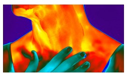
P Staff. Still from *Weed Killer*. 2017. Video (color, sound) 16:49 min. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Fund for the Twenty-First Century. © 2019 Patrick Staff. Courtesy the artist

***Weed Killer* explores the paradox of chemotherapy, a medical treatment that is both curative and poisonous. To create the work, you use a thermal imaging camera that makes the body appear abstract through hyper-saturated colors, while also bringing it into closer view by providing an intimate picture of its hot and cool areas. Could you talk about this contradiction and why you chose to use thermal imaging technology?**

The type of thermal cameras we used are most commonly used in medical and engineering professions. They use heat sensors to identify inflammation, tumors, and broken bones, or they can pinpoint the specific area where a machine malfunctions. I think most of us associate thermal images with surveillance and warfare, seeking out camouflaged criminals. I wanted to leave all of these associations open to viewers. It can produce a sense of unease but, paradoxically, the images are also quite beautiful, giving complex life to the surface of the skin and possibly the surface of the image. It draws our attention to how alive and active the skin is, this membrane that separates our outer and inner worlds. I am interested in trying to evoke this aliveness and porousness in the surface of the image—both on the film and in the space of the gallery.

Why do you feature your own body in *Weed Killer*? Could you talk about your use of performance, choreography, and the importance of movement in your work?

I'm interested in various strategies of implicating myself in the work. I suppose I experience putting artwork in a gallery as a process of us all becoming implicated, accountable, coming together in a shared experience. That happens both in the video and in the room it is shown in. It happens in how Catherine is a friend of mine, able to speak back to the work even if just privately to me. Debra [Soshoux] and Jamie [Crewe] are both performers that I work with, care about, and paid to perform. They bring their own agency to the work. I needed to put myself in the mix, too, to dance with everybody else in the video even if just momentarily.

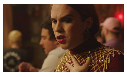


P Staff. Still from *Weed Killer*. 2017. Video (color, sound) 16:49 min. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Fund for the Twenty-First Century. © 2019 Patrick Staff. Courtesy the artist

One passage in *Weed Killer* features a "duet" between your body in motion and a cement mixer. Tell us about this scene and the relationship it explores between the human and the non-human. What is the significance of the soundtrack you developed for this sequence?

The sound in *Weed Killer* is very important. I worked with clarinet and alto sax musician Logan Hone. I go through phases of being fixated on different types of sound and music in my work—at this point I wanted to hear a lot of wind and reed instruments. I asked Logan to improvise, but to try to break the instrument: blow too hard, or too soft, or until you have no breath left. Break the notes, make them waiver or splutter and explode. In the recording, you hear him gasping for breath or frantically pressing the keys on the instrument. There is a somatic impulse in all of this.

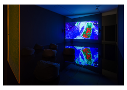
Similarly, I wanted to include a sort of pas de deux between myself and a machine. Just to have a hypnotic pause, a moment of motion and churning that can be at once beautiful and unsettling. Both my body and the cement mixer are making or moving heat around and, again, there is a sense of implication or exchange in this.



P Staff. Still from *Weed Killer*. 2017. Video (color, sound) 16:49 min. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Fund for the Twenty-First Century. © 2019 Patrick Staff. Courtesy the artist

I keep thinking about the longing for human connection that we experience throughout *Weed Killer*. How do you explore relationships in this work, including one's relationship to their own suffering?

I think there is a longing for human connection, but more pertinent for me is a sort of social curdling or dis-ease. Debra/Catherine is talking very intensely about compassion fatigue, depression, a sort of uncertainty about the limits of the body and, by proxy, the limits of what her community and the audience of the work can tolerate or contain. This gets kind of flipped in the bar scene with Jamie. She lip-syncs (perhaps mirroring Debra reading Catherine's text) in a bar filled with largely uninterested patrons. But she is having a transformative experience. There are tears in her eyes and she is getting worked-up enough to start screaming or pulling her hair out. There is all this cross-contamination going on, between affect and physical experience, between multiple viewers or audiences, the camera, the performers, gallery visitors, myself, Catherine, etc.



P Staff. *Weed Killer*. 2017. Video (color, sound) 16:49 min. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Fund for the Twenty-First Century. © 2019 Patrick Staff. Courtesy the artist. Installation view. Photo: Zak Kelley

***Weed Killer* is presented in a dark room with a reflective, high-shine black vinyl floor and transparent neon yellow acrylic panels opposite the screen. Why did you choose to present the work in such a reflective space?**

I wanted the whole space to feel like a refraction, like an oil slick or like it was glowing. I work a lot to consider the space in which a moving image work is encountered, which is one of the reasons I choose to present my work as a video installation. I have a background in dance, and I think a lot about the moment of encounter, about the liveness of the work. The image on the screen is as important as the surface you sit on, how it feels to the touch, where your body is situated. I think it comes back to implication, we've all got to go through the experience together.

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